Mastering Dirsearch: The Ultimate Web Directory Brute-Forcer

Dirsearch stands out as a powerhouse tool for web reconnaissance, designed specifically for discovering hidden directories, files, and endpoints on web servers. Unlike slower alternatives like Dirb, it leverages multithreading, intelligent filtering, and extensive customization to deliver rapid, precise results during penetration testing.[1] [2]

Why Choose Dirsearch?

This Python-based scanner excels in speed and flexibility, supporting recursion, custom headers, authentication, and multiple output formats like JSON or CSV. It's pre-installed on Kali Linux (`sudo apt install dirsearch`) and actively maintained on GitHub, ensuring compatibility with modern web apps. Professionals use it for mapping attack surfaces before deeper exploits.[2] [1]

Quick Installation Guide

On Kali/Debian:
`sudo apt update && sudo apt install dirsearch` – ready in seconds.[2]

From Source (Latest Features):

```
git clone https://github.com/maurosoria/dirsearch.git
cd dirsearch
pip3 install -r requirements.txt
python3 dirsearch.py --help
```

Add to PATH for global access: `sudo ln -s $(pwd)/dirsearch.py /usr/local/bin/dirsearch`.[3]

Default wordlists live in `/usr/share/dirsearch/wordlists/`, including `common.txt` for quick starts.[2]

Basic Scans: Get Started Fast

Launch with a target URL:
`dirsearch -u https://example.com`

This probes common paths with extensions like `.php`, `.asp`, showing live results:

```
[+] http://example.com/admin (CODE:200|SIZE:1234)
[+] http://example.com/login.php (CODE:200|SIZE:5678) [web:2]
```

Boost speed: `dirsearch -u https://target.com -t 50 -e php,html,js` – scans 50 threads, focusing on specified extensions.[1]

Essential Command Options

Master these for efficient reconnaissance:

Category	Option	Example	Purpose
Target	`-u URL`	`-u https://site.com`	Single URL [1]
	`-l FILE`	`-l urls.txt`	Batch from file
Wordlists	`-w LIST`	`-w /path/to/seclists.txt`	Custom dictionary
	`-e EXT`	`-e php,asp,aspx`	File extensions
Performance	`-t N`	`-t 100`	Thread count (default 25) [2]
	`--max-rate N`	`--max-rate 10`	Requests per second
Filtering	`-x CODES`	`-x 404,500-599`	Exclude status codes
	`--exclude-sizes`	`--exclude-sizes 0B,4kB`	Skip common sizes [1]
Output	`-o FILE`	`-o scan.json --format json`	Export results

Advanced Techniques

Recursion: Uncover nested directories: `dirsearch -u https://target.com -r -R 3` (depth 3). Use `--deep-recursive` for unlimited levels.[1]

Proxies & Auth: Bypass restrictions:
`dirsearch -u https://target.com --proxy http://127.0.0.1:8080 --auth user:pass -H "User-Agent: Mozilla/5.0"`[2]

POST Requests: Test forms: `dirsearch -u https://target.com -m POST -d "username=admin&password=pass"`[1]

Quiet Automation: `dirsearch -u https://target.com -q -o results.csv --format csv` – ideal for scripting.[1]

Real-World Examples

Bug Bounty Recon:
`dirsearch -u https://sub.domain.com -e bak,old,bak~ -x 404 -t 30 -R 2 -o bounty.json`
Filters noise, digs deep for backups.[4]

Authenticated Admin Hunt:
`dirsearch -u https://intranet.com --auth-type basic --auth admin:secret -w`

`/usr/share/seclists/Discovery/Web-Content/raft-large-directories.txt`[1]

CIDR Scanning: `dirsearch --cidr 192.168.1.0/24 -e php` – sweeps networks.[1]

Configuration Tips

Tweak `/etc/dirsearch/default.conf` for presets:

```
[default]
threads=50
timeout=10
extensions=php,asp,aspx,js
request_by_hostname=true
```

Override per-scan: `--config myconfig.ini`.[5] [1]

Pro Tip: Pair with SecLists (`/usr/share/seclists/Discovery/Web-Content/`) for massive wordlists.[2]

Best Practices & Legal Notes

- **Ethics First:** Only scan authorized targets – unauthorized use violates laws.[6]
- **Stealth:** Throttle with `-s 0.5` (0.5s delay) to evade WAFs; rotate `--random-agent`.
- **Efficiency:** Exclude 404s early (`-x 404`), pipe to grep: `dirsearch ... | grep "200"`.
- **Chain Tools:** Follow hits with `nuclei` or `ffuf` for vulns.[4]

Dirsearch transforms raw brute-forcing into surgical precision, making it indispensable for pentesters. Experiment responsibly to map web apps like a pro.[1]

⁂

1. https://github.com/maurosoria/dirsearch
2. https://www.kali.org/tools/dirsearch/
3. https://infosecwriteups.com/install-dirsearch-on-kali-4d5e7096676a
4. https://www.blackhillsinfosec.com/how-to-use-dirsearch/
5. https://manpages.ubuntu.com/manpages/jammy/man1/dirsearch.1.html
6. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6OjHyiMAx94